Promotion

Unit 1 · 1.3.3.3 Promotion and branding

Promotion is the marketing activity used to communicate with customers to inform and persuade them to buy. Firms blend several methods — the **promotional mix**.

Types of promotion

- **Advertising** — paid messages via TV, radio, social media or billboards (e.g. McDonald's global campaigns).
- **Sales promotion** — short-term incentives: coupons, app deals, free samples, product trials (e.g. H&M seasonal discounts).
- **Personal selling** — staff selling face to face, common for high-value goods (e.g. Rolex boutique staff).
- **Public relations (PR)** — managing public image via press releases and events (e.g. Apple's iPhone launches create huge free publicity).
- **Direct & digital marketing** — tailored emails, app notifications, social media (e.g. Amazon recommendations, Starbucks campaigns).

Above and below the line

- **Above-the-line (ATL)** — advertising through mass media to reach a wide audience (e.g. Pepsi's Super Bowl ads). Builds awareness fast but costly and untargeted.
- **Below-the-line (BTL)** — communication the firm controls directly, not using mass media (personal selling, sales promotion, direct marketing). Cheaper and more targeted.

Technology in promotion

- **Targeted online advertising** — ads aimed at customers whose online activity shows interest (e.g. Amazon recommendations).
- **Viral advertising** — shareable content spread by users (e.g. ALS Ice Bucket Challenge; Nike “Dream Crazy”).
- **E-newsletters** — opt-in email lists sending offers (e.g. IKEA personalised recommendations).

These methods are low-cost and highly targeted, but the firm has less control over how messages spread and must avoid overwhelming customers.